

Chapter 160-3

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The guess was never verified.

Liang Shi didn't have any personal belongings from anyone in the Shen family.

Gu Yixue was newly married, but if she were to rudely ask, "Director Gu, could you give me a toothbrush that Shen Fenghe has used? Or give me a strand of Shen Fenghe's hair."

She would probably be seen by Gu Yixue as having some kind of fetish.

Or Gu Yixue would figure it out in less than a minute.

Making guesses was one thing, but planning to do a DNA test was another matter entirely.

The former might be fantasy; the latter would be blatant freeloading¹.

Yet the logical chain in between seemed to form a closed loop.

Qiu Zimin, because she had become enemies with Zhu Mingqi, after her own daughter was stolen, went and stole Zhu Mingqi's daughter, then raised her daughter under her wing, turning her into a deviant as revenge.

But the problem was that everyone in the Shen family thought that child had died.

It was a premature death, not a disappearance.

So no one suspected that Liang Shi could be a child of the Shen family.

Actually, Liang Shi herself shouldn't suspect either—after all, Shen Fenghe had solemnly said her younger sister had died young. But the countless times people mentioned her similar eye color, and the fact that she wasn't Qiu Zimin's biological child, made her unable to resist suspecting.

Especially since Zhu Mingqi said she knew Qiu Zimin.

The truth seemed to be right before her eyes.

But Liang Shi had no choice but to give up because she couldn't get their personal belongings.

She actually didn't want to search for her birth family.

Being alone like this was fine too.

Just like Liang Xinran²—although she had searched for her family and found her biological parents, the lost years were still lost. She was already this old and had long developed the habit of being independent. She didn't lack money or love; she wasn't at an age where she absolutely needed to find her parents.

Returning to acknowledge relatives would inevitably cause a huge commotion, like throwing a stone into a calm, still lake—it would create layer upon layer of ripples.

Liang Shi felt it would be very awkward.

She would resist from the very beginning any environment that made her feel at a loss.

After accompanying Gu Yixue to crash the wedding and achieving a pretty good result, Liang Shi's days afterward were uneventful.

A few days later, her agent called her to participate in a variety show—the kind where you make appearances on regular variety shows to gain exposure.

Because she didn't have a representative work yet, and her only work was the red outfit look that had gone viral before, they asked if she could dance. They wanted to arrange a mid-show performance slot for her, just wearing red—either in ancient costume or modern attire would be fine.

This variety show aired weekly with high public recognition and national popularity. This time, a slot had opened up entirely because a senior from their company had let it go. It was originally that senior's spot, but because she had temporarily joined a production—a big director's drama—she couldn't be bothered with this kind of exposure variety show anymore.

Actually, once you went in, you might not even get three lines—one self-introduction, a short supporting performance, one "thank you," one "goodbye."

Whether even those three lines would make the final cut was uncertain.

But for a newcomer, this opportunity was a pretty good resource.

When the time came, they could buy a hot search³, and it would be easier to find drama and movie resources for Liang Shi.

Because Liang Shi's face was more refined and better suited for the big screen, her agent wanted her to star in movies, heading straight for the goal of "Box Office Queen." Plus, with her role in Gu Yixue's movie, once "Heart's Journey" was released, it might be a double harvest of reputation and box office. Then she wouldn't be considered without works.

Even if she couldn't win Best Actress, getting an international nomination for Best Newcomer definitely wouldn't be a problem.

The agent had planned her path very well, so when she came to ask, she used a very firm tone, with an implication of "you must participate."

However, Liang Shi could also refuse.

This agent was similar to Sister Wang—she wouldn't force you to do anything, and she would give you opportunities, but if you didn't seize them, sorry, there wouldn't be a next time.

Back when Liang Shi first joined the company, Sister Wang also had several newcomers under her. But Liang Shi was the most talented, the least picky about work, and the best at seizing opportunities—unlike many newcomers who had just entered the entertainment industry, who were particularly impetuous and wanted big directors and good roles right from the start.

Liang Shi would only choose what was most advantageous to herself within an appropriate range.

So Liang Shi understood the agent's underlying message. Without even asking what dance she would be doing or how many days of rehearsal there would be, she accepted without hesitation.

The agent smiled with satisfaction and only then explained the time, location, and collaboration partners clearly.

There was one day of rehearsal time. Since it would be with three other artists from their company, those three would be promoting their new song while she was an extra member. The dance was in a Chinese traditional style, and she needed to learn fan dancing.

Fan dancing involved relatively difficult movements, including several high-difficulty aerial spins that would be performed by the center position among the four. Liang Shi wouldn't have much focus on her.

The agent specifically emphasized this.

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "Got it, I'll cherish this opportunity."

The agent also reminded her: "Don't steal too much of the spotlight."

Liang Shi knew this too and immediately agreed, "Understood."

The former was the agent testing her reaction—to see if she lacked self-awareness, thinking that being on stage meant she'd get lots of solo shots, and that she could go viral across the internet just with a set of amazing photos like before.

The latter was because the agent saw she didn't have those messy ulterior motives, so she gave her this advice.

In this industry, don't offend seniors who aren't very famous yet, especially those in the same company who haven't made it big.

The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out⁴.

Liang Shi deeply understood this principle.

She roughly knew what level the agent wanted her to maintain.

The recording was in two days, and she only had one day of rehearsal. Everyone else had already practiced on their own and just needed to run through formations a few times. Liang Shi was undoubtedly behind.

The agent sent her a video and told her to practice first. Tomorrow, a car would pick her up and take her to the dance studio.

It would be best if she could directly join the others in formation practice.

Once Liang Shi got the video, she threw herself into practice.

She was still staying at Zhao Xuning's place and didn't really want to move out and face an empty house alone.

Liang Shi casually tied her hair into a fluffy bun.

There were T-shirts in the closet. She changed into a white one, and because there were wave movements, she rolled up the hem of her shirt, exposing the abs on her abdomen, and tied up the side with a small hair tie.

For pants, she wore comfortable black joggers, placed a yoga mat under her feet, and practiced facing the mirror.

She didn't have a dance background, but she had played an ancient dancer before, so she had done a crash course with a teacher previously and knew a little bit.

However, she was quite skilled with fans, because she had played a martial arts hero. A folding fan would fly out, and when it flew back, the tip of the fan would be stained with a layer of blood. Normally, she had to spin the fan—not only spin it fast but also make it look good.

At the most extreme, she had spun the fan for three consecutive days, to the point where the moment her hand held a fan, she would subconsciously spin it.

Footnotes:

¹ **Blatant freeloading (碰瓷兒):** A Chinese slang term originally referring to a scam where someone deliberately gets hit by a car or breaks something to extort money. Here it's used more broadly to mean taking advantage of someone or making unfounded claims to benefit from a situation—in this case, trying to claim family ties without solid evidence.

² **Liang Xinran:** Note that the original text uses "梁欣然" which appears to be the same character mentioned in the translation guidelines as "郭欣然 = Guo Xinran." However, the character here is written with the surname "Liang" (梁) in the original, which may be a typo or different character. Translation kept as written in original.

³ **Buy a hot search (買熱搜):** In Chinese social media (particularly Weibo), "hot searches" are trending topics. Entertainment companies often pay to get their artists' names or related topics onto the trending list to increase exposure.

⁴ **The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out (槍打出頭鳥):** A Chinese proverb meaning that those who stand out or draw attention to themselves will be targeted. It advises against being too conspicuous or showing off.